

# 50 Modal verbs overview

Modal verbs are used to talk about likelihood, ability, permission, and obligation, among other things. They often refer to hypothetical situations.

-  **New language** Using modal verbs
-  **Vocabulary** Modal verbs
-  **New skill** Asking, offering, and predicting

## 50.1 KEY LANGUAGE MODAL VERBS

Modal verbs share certain characteristics. They don't change form depending on the subject, they are always followed by an infinitive, and their question and negative forms are made without "do."

### Logical deductions

It **can't** be Jane because she's on vacation.  
It **could** / **might** / **may** be Dave. I don't know.  
It **should** be my dad. He said he'd call me.  
It **must** be Tom, since nobody else ever calls.



### Obligation

You **must** arrive on time for work.



### Permission

You **can** have more cake if you want.  
You **may** take as much as you like.



### Ability

I **can** speak three languages.  
I **can't** read Latin because it's too difficult.  
I **couldn't** study it when I was at school.



### Requests

**Can** / **Could** you give me a ride home later?  
**Would** you email James for me, please?  
**Will** you lock up the office tonight?



### Advice and suggestions

You **should** / **ought to** go to the doctor.  
You **could** try the new medicine.



### Offers

**Can** I help you with those?  
**Shall** I carry some of your bags?

